



“God Is With Us, Even on the Internet”

The Role of AI Chatbots in the Right to Freedom of Religious Expression

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Introduction

The fabric of traditional and typical Filipino experience involves the threads of religiosity; it has been the long-standing image of the country of being strong in faith. No matter which religion it may be, the Filipino believer often incorporates the practices of their beliefs into their everyday lives. For the average Catholic this can manifest as having the routine of praying before every meal or attending mass every Sunday, to name a few. The tight fusion of religion into the lives of people feeds the peculiar interest in discovering the relationship between freedom of religious expression and the rising prominence of modern society that is reliant on technological advancements.

In this modern day and age, technology is as omnipresent and omniscient as religious deities, this is to say not only is it present in every aspect of our lives but also now possesses endless knowledge that even the human mind cannot easily contain and immediately comprehend. The era of Artificial Intelligence (AI) is emerging in recent years, in particular the AI Chatbots have been gaining popularity for its convenience and efficiency. The question that emerges then is *what happens when modern technology crashes into the life of the believer?* The unique tapestry of religion and technology emerges which gives birth to the utilization of tech to express such beliefs, as such Artificial Intelligence in particular has been a popular tool that people can use as a means to express their faith.

The moral and spiritual function of AI is unprecedented and is unexplored by the field of law, especially in the Philippines. However it is this undeniable gap that should pique our interest into the possible legal implications of the role of AI, specifically chatbots, in the constitutional right of Filipinos in expressing their religious beliefs and opinions.



The Rise of Artificial Intelligence

The prevalence of technology is undeniable in the current age as it has deeply embedded itself in the everyday lives of your average person with the purpose of making tasks efficient. The weight of daily activities have lessened for the human to carry as the machine has taken on the burden of executing the labor. Human society has gone from physically playing their favorite artist on their phone to a simple “Hey Siri, play me a song”; people have gone from manually figuring out the best way to avoid traffic to having an application that directs you to the fastest route possible. This efficiency is what allows Artificial Intelligence to prosper and become omnipresent in today’s society.

The beauty of Artificial Intelligence (AI) lies in the fact that a machine built on intricate codes of data, is able to mimic human intelligence so that it may perform certain tasks it was programmed to do. The main purpose of AI is to study the human mind through algorithms so that it may imitate the ability to think, learn, problem-solve, and believe in concepts that are rooted in the knowledge of humans.¹ The popular examples of AI are in the form of virtual assistants such as Siri programmed by Apple and Alexa by Amazon. However, the technology is not merely used for dictating a computer to do routine tasks or errands for you, but can even be utilized to mimic human interactions. The other form of AI that is presently gaining traction and criticism is called chatbot, and these are computer programs that aim to stimulate human conversations.² Among the progressive versions of a chatbot is popularly known to be ChatGPT, a generative AI assistant that is known for its flexibility, and it operates through the use of a few prompts from the user to achieve outputs such as essays, drawings, codes, and actual casual conversations with the AI.³

In the seemingly infinite possibilities that one can make use of AI Chatbots, the expression of faith is not an exemption. The impact of AI has crept into Religion that faith-based programs have been growing with the

¹ Rituraj Mahato, *Artificial Intelligence, What is it?*, The Outcomes of Best Practices in Classroom Research. 197, 197 (2022).

² IBM, *Artificial Intelligence: What is a chatbot?*, <https://www.ibm.com/think/topics/chatbots> (last visited October 31, 2025)

³ Barbara Pazur, *What is ChatGPT? Everything you need to know about the AI chatbot*, Cnet (May 14, 2025), <https://www.cnet.com/tech/services-and-software/what-is-chatgpt-everything-you-need-to-know-about-the-ai-chatbot/>



purpose of providing spiritual comfort and guidance to the believer. An example of this AI Chatbot is the application called “Text with Jesus” that allows its users to ask questions about Joseph, Mary, Jesus, and other figures of Christianity. This marks a new function of AI, which is the ability to possess a sense of moral authority as it becomes a tool for feeding people spiritual guidance in times of doubt. The appeal of such chatbots is that when humans are faced with the difficult questions of life the Godbots can provide answers⁴ with just one click of their thumbs.

The Intersection of Law and AI chatbots

The interesting question now lies in how such advancement of technology impacts the field of the legal system. In the reality of current society, we are painted a picture of humans living their lives with the aid of machines to the point where it is impossible to see a person without a smart device—from their phones, watches, eyeglasses, and even cars. As things stand, people are surrounded by AI that it is almost impossible to live a day without coming into contact with such technology, thus it is imperative that we question what the possible legal implications this era of technology brings to the table.

To put things in perspective, the ongoing case of *Garcia v. Character Technologies, Inc.* is an example of the intersection of technology and the law. The plaintiff, Megan Garcia, the mother of the 14 year old Sewell who killed himself, is suing the owner of a famous chatbot platform, Character Technologies, Inc. The said platform, *character.ai*, was used by Sewell obsessively; he was communicating often with the chatbot that there were conversations about his plans on taking his own life. His mother argues to the court that the AI preyed on her son’s existing depression and encouraged him to go through with his plans after seeing the texts exchanged between the two: the chatbot, at one point, had asked Sewell if he had devised the plans to kill himself, the latter admitted that he did but was unsure if it would work or cause him great pain, to that the former replied with “that’s not a reason not to go through with it”.⁵

⁴ Michigan News, *Are you there, AI? It’s me, God*, University of Michigan (October 04, 2023), <https://news.umich.edu/are-you-there-ai-its-me-god/>

⁵ Blake Montgomery, *Mother says AI chatbot led her son to kill himself in lawsuit against its maker*, The Guardian (October 23, 2024), <https://www.theguardian.com/technology/2024/oct/23/character-ai-chatbot-sewell-setzer-death>



The American court has allowed the case of Megan Garcia to proceed on various claims for torts, wrongful death, and the violation of Florida Deceptive and Unfair Trade Practices Act, while her claims on intentional emotional distress were rejected.⁶ The point is, the case only introduces us to the question of how much liability can we place on AI chatbots when involved in legal cases. This only cements the fact that from this day forward, more issues can arise where humans are demanding justice from acts of AI; that society is currently evolving into the technological future people have always pictured it to be, and so our legal system must anticipate the legal implications of the undeniable intersection between the two.

The Right to Religion and the role of AI

Article III, Section 5 of the 1987 Constitution states that “*no law shall be made respecting an establishment of religion, or prohibiting the free exercise thereof. The free exercise and enjoyment of religious profession and worship, without discrimination or preference, shall forever be allowed. No religious test shall be required for the exercise of civil or political rights.*”⁷ The Constitution ensures that every Filipino citizen is afforded the right to have and hold religious beliefs, and that they are able to exercise as such the practices involved in their religion. In the era of technological advancement, we start to ponder how the exercise of such right is manifested, specifically through the persisting presence of Artificial Intelligence that is starting to influence the different aspects of human life and experience. With the rise of AI chatbots such as *Text with Jesus*, we start to wonder if it can constitute as a practice and expression of religious belief.

Current jurisprudence already establishes what is considered to be a religious practice—*Estrada v. Escritor* held that religion is defined by religious belief and conduct rooted in such beliefs, and that any act is considered as the latter when it is sincerely done in obedience to the religious belief.⁸ Going off with that definition, it can be considered then for religious AI Chatbots to be an

⁶ Rob Harkavy, *AI wrongful death lawsuit to proceed in Florida*, ICLG News (May 22, 2025), https://iclg.com/news/22623-ai-wrongful-death-lawsuit-to-proceed-in-florida?utm_source=chatgpt.com

⁷ CONST. (1987), art. III, §5 (Phil.).

⁸ *Estrada v. Escritor*, A.M. No. P-02-1651, (August 04, 2003) (Phil.).



exercise of religious practice by Filipino Citizens, so long as it is done so in good faith. However, one might wonder how exactly an AI chatbot can constitute as a practice of religion? The experience of devout Catholics like Michael Bulawan and Aiene Molina are prominent examples, where the former uses AI chatbots to seek comfort from AI by asking it to help break down bible passages to him, and the latter utilizes AI chatbot to explain bible verses whenever she is unable to attend Sunday church activities.⁹ In this day and age, AI chatbots are present in the lives of Filipinos as it is a source of comfort and strength for their faith. Such usage of AI is a clear display of religious practice that has evolved from its traditional application. This phenomenon is not limited to the Philippines as even the oldest church of Switzerland has adapted to the presence of AI by installing “*Deus in Machina*” the AI Jesus that engages in conversation with hundreds of believers coming to see him and asking for advice.¹⁰ The emergence of this contemporary application of what can constitute as a practice of religion must be noted as it involves the constitutional right of the Filipino citizens.

Regulation through Laws

The fields of technology and of the law undeniably intersect with one another, however given that the legal liability of tech such as AI is novel, its possible legal implications of AI in the human experience still lack the proper scholarly and legal exploration. American jurisprudence has shown to us that it is possible for AI chatbots to be sued for the role it played in the suicide of a teenager¹¹, it gave us a peek into the possible scenarios wherein AI may face the legal justice system. While it does introduce to us this possibility, much is still left unknown in the realm of AI and jurisprudence, but we may learn from what we already know to prepare ourselves for what may come in the future. The best way to face the world of tomorrow is to equip the legal system with the proper tools in applying the law to AI.

⁹ Ronaldo Reyes, *Filipino Catholics finds joy, comfort in AI in strengthening faith*, Sunstar (May 21, 2024), https://www.sunstar.com.ph/tacloban/filipino-catholics-find-joy-comfort-in-ai-in-strengthening-faith#google_vignette

¹⁰ Brian Cheng, *‘Deus in Machina’: Swiss church installs AI Jesus to connect the digital and divine*, NBC News (December 06, 2024), <https://www.nbcnews.com/news/world/deus-machina-swiss-church-installs-ai-jesus-connect-digital-divine-rcna182973>

¹¹ Montgomery, *Supra* note 5



While Article III, Section 5 of the 1987 Constitution provides the Free Exercise Clause which affords protection to the right of an individual to hold their religious beliefs and convictions, and thus prohibits the state from questioning such beliefs, it is not absolute as per the benevolent-neutrality principle which provides that state may allow for exceptions when upholding its role in protecting the fundamental right of religious freedom.¹² Thus, while the constitution prohibits the government from interfering in the use of AI chatbots as a means to express religious beliefs, it may, however, regulate when harm and hate arise from the use of such technology.

In terms of harm arising from the use of AI chatbots for religious purposes, what is meant here is the presence of ill-intent in the utilization of the technology, exploitation being a prime example. This refers to when AI chatbots are being used to take advantage of an individual's religious belief and cause harm to their emotional or even financial standing, case in point the American case of the teenager who was further pushed by the AI chatbot to take his own life.¹³ On the other hand, hate can arise when AI chatbots are utilized to spread animosity, particularly about another religion, on the guise of being the words of the deity they believe in. Harm and hate are important to avoid in the rising popularity of AI chatbots in society, so that in instances where an individual is subjected to them, accountability can be easily identified and consequences can be served.

Conclusion

When the public safety, order, and rights of others are being infringed upon, the state is able to intervene on issues involving religion, so long as it does not violate the separation of the church and state, that is to say it does not deliberately align and promote a religion and remains neutral. In the case of AI chatbots and religion, regulation must be considered, especially on the liability that the owners of such AI programs in instances that it violates the rights of the citizens during their pursuit of religious expression. Legislation then must be established that protects Filipino citizens while exercising their right to religious expression through AI, specifically via chatbots. It is only the duty of the state to protect such rights, and amidst the contemporary issue of

¹² *Supra* note 8

¹³ Montgomery, *Supra* note 5



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Artificial Intelligence, we must be prepared in facing such challenges. Religious expression and practice has become advanced, and it is only natural for the state to keep up with the changing times, that is to say legislation must be made with the purpose of addressing new issues.

In the pursuit of religious comfort and guidance, it is unsurprising that people have looked towards AI in providing them an efficient solution because with just a click of a finger they can access religious relief from the glare of their phones at home. While it may be currently deemed as an unconventional practice, sooner or later it would become as normal as having a watch that you can talk to. Thus, it is imperative that the state should address the elephant in the room, the legal implications of such religious practice, and form the proper remedies so that the life and liberty of Filipinos are not put in jeopardy while in the exercise of their religious beliefs and convictions.

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